

The fight to control the EU's purse strings

送信者: POLITICO Brussels Playbook 受信日時: 2026-10-01 14:02

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CIAO THERE. It's Gerardo Fortuna.

In today's Playbook:

- The Commission has been building a backup comms tool — but the reviews are brutal.
- The Netherlands wants Brussels to go after drug traffickers, wherever they're hiding.
- Faces in the crowd: Pascal Lamy, David van Weel, Maria Teresa Fàbregas Fernández, Andy Burnham, Nicolas Schmit, Matthew Hodgson, Bolle Jos, Piotr Serafin, Isabelle Durant, Declan Costello and more ...

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Sarah discuss how Ukraine will survive another winter under fire and short on cash.

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DRIVING THE DAY

EXCLUSIVE — WHO CONTROLS EU SPENDING? Today sees the latest flashpoint in the ongoing tussle between Brussels and national capitals over who holds the purse strings in the EU's next seven-year budget — with a discussion at the European Commission that will potentially send shivers through national governments.

At the behind-closed-doors meeting, Commission officials Declan Costello and Maria Teresa Fàbregas Fernández will present to government experts “examples of reforms, investments and outputs” and discuss “regional and territorial aspects” of the approximately €2 trillion budget (amounting to half of

it), according to an agenda obtained by Gregorio Sorigi.

Red flags ahoy: That wording might look innocuous, but it speaks to precisely the issues capitals are nervous about.

Something else might alarm them: The meeting was convened and coordinated by Ursula von der Leyen's powerful Secretariat-General. Costello — who runs SG REFORM, a task force within the secgen — is to open the discussion. That's significant because SG REFORM helped steer the post-Covid recovery fund — precisely the cash-for-reforms experiment that is the blueprint for von der Leyen's new spending model and which makes governments so uneasy.

The new system will sideline regions and give the Commission too much control, some governments fear. "We did and will today again make clear that there is no room for diluting the regional dimension," said a Polish government official, granted anonymity because the whole discussion is so sensitive.

The Commission's controversial plan is to bundle agriculture, regional and migration spending into national cash pots known as National and Regional Partnership Plans, or NRPPs.

Even more sensitive is making payments conditional on governments delivering economic reforms, like in the recovery fund. Ten countries, from Poland to Luxembourg, have already pushed back, worried that Brussels could demand politically explosive changes to pensions or the judiciary.

So today's meeting offers a revealing glimpse, not just into the push and pull between Commission and governments over who gets to open the wallet, but also into how von der Leyen is centralizing that power in the Commission itself.

Because while the secgen leads the whole thing, the Commission departments that have traditionally had the spending power are left as bit-part players. DG AGRI can send four people, with extras dispatched to a listening room, one official said. DGs REGIO, HOME, EMPL and MARE will join too, according to another official. All are involved in the NRPPs but are among the services facing potential mergers in a forthcoming Commission mega-reshuffle.

The direction of travel is becoming clearer, the meeting signals. Budget power is moving toward von der Leyen's inner circle — meaning whoever succeeds her could inherit considerably more control over how Europe spends its cash.

BIG AND BREAKING

WAR OF ATTRITION: Vladimir Putin is ramping up strikes on Ukraine at the worst possible moment for Kyiv, with winter looming and its war chest running low — but the conflict is also taking a terrible toll on Russia, Veronika Melkozerova and Jan Cieski report .

FROZEN OUT: The Trump administration is excluding several major allies from a NATO meeting in Poland next month, including France, the U.K. and the Baltic countries, POLITICO reports .

LET US SPEND: Italian PM Giorgia Meloni says she'll ask Ursula von der Leyen to relax the Commission's fiscal rules so governments can help companies and families deal with energy-driven price rises. She wants the issue discussed at upcoming Ecofin and European Council meetings.

BURNHAM'S RESET: Andy Burnham will try to relaunch the U.K.'s relationship with the EU at a summit in November after both sides set aside a dispute over the bloc's "Made in Europe" requirements, the

Financial Times reports .

Burnham's suggestion that Britain could rejoin the EU has been welcomed by Emmanuel Macron and Pedro Sánchez — but Brussels is keeping a poker face. "We remain open to engaging on the options it may put forward," a spokesperson said.

BACK TO BRUSSELS: Romania's parliament yesterday rejected Siegfried Mureșan's attempt to form a government , sending the EU budget negotiator back to his day job.

SCHENGEN SHOWDOWN: Former European Commissioners Josep Borrell, Nicolas Schmit and László Andor are backing a Good Lobby complaint accusing Brussels of failing to defend Schengen after Italy extended border checks again, warning that inaction risks weakening citizens' rights and the European legal order.

MS TEAMS VS. EUROPEAN TECH

NO EU IN MS TEAMS: The European Commission's Trump-proof alternative to Microsoft Teams has drawn ridicule from EU officials, who told Playbook the tool is "absolute shit."

Plan B: Over the summer, the bloc's executive rolled out Element Pro, which a staff memo seen by Playbook billed as a "sovereign back-up to Teams." While Teams remains the Commission's main communications tool, Element Pro is "an internal back-up tool that helps ensure our business continuity" in the event of "disruption." Translation: if Washington decides to turn off American tech.

"In recent months, digital sovereignty has become increasingly important," the Commission told staff in July. "In practice, this means having greater control over our data and systems so that we can reduce risks and limit disruption to our work, wherever possible."

It's not exactly a hit: "I don't understand the added value here," an official complained. "It's absolute shit," according to another. And one told Playbook that, based on how well the Teams alternative works, the U.S. would "instantly win the war" if it does ever decide to switch off its tech.

In their element: Because the Commission hosts the Element system on its own infrastructure, rather than relying on Microsoft's cloud, it's supposed to be more secure. "That is not the case with Teams, where all we have is a guarantee that Microsoft will not peek inside," an official said in internal communications viewed by Playbook.

It's not just the Commission. Earlier this year, France announced that millions of civil servants will stop using U.S. video conferencing tools, including Microsoft Teams and Zoom, by 2027 and switch to a homegrown alternative called Visio. Austria's military replaced Microsoft Office with the German LibreOffice last year.

Teams, but not: Element is a U.K. company whose software is already used by some governments in Europe. It works much the same way as Teams, with staff able to hold "audio and video calls with Commission colleagues," the Commission staff memo reads.

Changing up: Element CEO Matthew Hodgson said "change is always painful, particularly if it's" a switch from a much-used program "like Teams." He added that Element was supporting the EU throughout the rollout and wanted to hear all feedback, good or bad.

******On 29 October, the 6th European Defence & Security Conference (EDSC) will bring together policymakers, military leaders, industry executives and experts at Brussels' Egmont Palace to discuss Europe's defence and security priorities. A leading forum for dialogue on strategic, technological and industrial challenges, EDSC fosters stronger European defence cooperation and strategic autonomy. Register here ******

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

It's October, and the European Parliament will be making two trips to Strasbourg. Why? It's because the EU treaties say that the Parliament must hold 12 plenary sessions a year in the French city. Since the Parliament takes August off, it needs to make two trips to Strasbourg during another month, which is October. This year, the Parliament is holding a total of 15 plenary sessions (a plenary is a meeting of the whole Parliament), with the remaining three in Brussels.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: On the Brussels Playbook Podcast, Zoya asked whether your employer is trying to replace U.S. tech. WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

CRACKING DOWN ON CRIME

DUTCH PUSH TO TARGET DRUG TRAFFICKERS: The Netherlands will today urge Brussels to swiftly adopt a new sanctions regime enabling countries to target drug traffickers anywhere in the world, Dutch Justice Minister David van Weel told Playbook's Nick Vinocur.

When to watch: He will be leading the push during a Justice and Home Affairs Council today, piling pressure on the European Commission to make good on a pledge from the 2025 State of the Union speech.

The case study: The issue has become a major priority — and diplomatic headache — for The Hague after a fugitive drug trafficker locally known as “Bolle Jos” (translation: chubby Jos) turned up in Sierra Leone, which is refusing requests to extradite him to the Netherlands for prosecution.

Hiding out: “That calls for new measures, not only against him, but against all those organized crime criminals that we're not able to detain immediately, but that are really harming our national security,” van Weel told Playbook.

Why the holdup? Previous attempts to set up a sanctions regime for organized crime have met pushback from national law enforcement agencies, who fear sanctions could impede investigations. But there's more support for the move now, said van Weel. “I'm hoping that we can conclude this regime by the end of the year.”

6 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

RETURN HUBS ARE GO: EU ministers are set to greenlight new deportation rules today, as the summer chaos in Ceuta looms over migration talks in Luxembourg.

SCOOP — CLIMATE FINANCE FALTERS: The EU's draft position for COP31 contains a veiled swipe at the Trump administration's pressure campaign against development banks, Zia Weise reports for

subscribers in Morning Energy & Climate .

MERZ HOLDS THE LINE ON UKRAINE: German Chancellor Friedrich Merz will use a speech at today's International Westphalian Peace Prize ceremony in Münster to reaffirm Germany's backing for Ukraine — even as domestic support wanes and the far left and far right argue that aid comes at the cost of social spending, Hans von der Burchard reports in Berlin Playbook.

NATO Secretary-General Mark Rutte — who'll accept the peace prize on behalf of NATO — rebuked Moscow yesterday for threatening nuclear escalation over military activity near its border, saying: "NATO is so much stronger than Russia is, so there's no way they can ever beat us."

CUE LA RESISTANCE: Emmanuel Macron and Mark Carney have turned trolling Donald Trump into an international double act — but is taking on the U.S. president really a smart strategy? Jamie Dettmer unpacks the risks .

BORING IS GOOD: The EU's budget chief Piotr Serafin will tout growing Asian and Middle Eastern demand for EU bonds today — pitching boring, predictable Europe as an increasingly attractive investment in a volatile world. More in Morning Financial Services for subscribers .

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Cloudy with rain expected in the morning. High 20C.

POST-BREXIT BALL: The U.K. Mission to the EU will tonight host a glitzy "Music Sounds Better With You" concert for the hippest movers and shakers in the Brussels bubble, in celebration of the European music industry and Britain's contribution to it. The invite-only bash features live performances by French singer Benjamin Diamond, rock band VENUS GRRRLS and Scottish indie group The Snuts.

Costly affair: The event comes amid serious concerns about the impact of post-Brexit restrictions on the music business, with a U.K. government analysis concluding that the country's touring sector lost £208 million and almost 2,500 jobs between 2022 and 2024. Work visa requirements and rules for shipping equipment have caused tours to be canceled and delayed, leaving European fans missing out and costing the EU £1 billion and around 17,000 jobs, the analysis said.

On the agenda: U.K. Digital, Culture, Media and Sport Minister Ian Murray will raise the issue at tonight's party and London intends to bring it up at a bilateral summit with the EU expected next month.

SPOTTED ... at the Friends of Europe gala dinner at the Art & History Museum in Parc du Cinquantenaire, sipping Silly Billy brewskies and organic cava, tucking into smoked ricotta with pickled beetroot and black cod with celeriac mousseline and sweating through sauna-level heat: Jacques Delors Friends of Europe Foundation's Pascal Lamy and Isabelle Durant, an unlikely comedy duo, who presented former Italian PM Enrico Letta with four T-shirts for his 60th birthday with slogans including "60 candles, zero tariffs," "Letta, c'est moi" (the crowd lost it at that one) and "I love SM (Single Market)." Try the veal, they're here all night.

Also present ... to hear Letta deliver a rousing address calling on Europe to take a leaf out of Donald Trump's playbook and be its own biggest cheerleader: Former Swedish PM Carl Bildt; Moldova's Deputy Prime Minister Mihai Popoi; Romania's Foreign Minister Oana Ciuiu; Aleksandar Nikoloski, North Macedonia's first deputy prime minister; Lithuania's Culture Minister Lukas Alsys; MEPs Petras

Auštrevičius, Brando Benifei, Dóra Dávid and Marc Angel; China's Ambassador to the EU Cai Run; Oksana Diakun, deputy head of Ukraine's mission to the EU; Iceland's Ambassador to the EU Stefán Haukur Jóhannesson; DG ENV's Deputy Director-General Patrick Child; Genoveva Ruiz Calavera, director-general of the Commission's Interpretation department; Giuseppe Cavo Dragone, chair of NATO's Military Committee; Sebastian Vos, founder of Axis Partners; Vincent Houssiau, chief of cabinet to the king of the Belgians; and POLITICO's Zoya Sheftalovich.

SPOTTED ... at a gathering of Croats working in the Brussels bubble, packed into the rain-slicked terrace at Grand Central: European Commission's Katarina Ivanković-Knežević, Sara Hjeltnes, Petar Zubić and Dino Toljan; European Parliament's Vesna Ravlić, Mato Škrabalo and Tsveta Ryahova; European Economic and Social Committee's David Hrvoje Hoić and Danko Relić; HRT's Brussels correspondent Vibor Vlanić; and POLITICO's Sebastian Starcevic.

SPOTTED ... at last night's celebration of the anniversary of German reunification at Concert Noble, complete with currywurst, apple strudel and a late-night DJ set: German Ambassador Thomas Ossowski; EU Defense Commissioner Andrius Kubilius; Crisis Management Commissioner Hadja Lahbib; European Parliament trade committee Chair Bernd Lange; European Parliament defense committee Chair Marie-Agnes Strack-Zimmermann; French Ambassador to the EU Philippe Léglise-Costa; Australian Ambassador Angus Campbell; Canadian Ambassador Jonathan Wilkinson; the European Council president's chief of staff Pedro Lourtie, deputy chief of staff David Oppenheimer and spokesperson Maria Tomasik; U.S. Deputy Ambassador Norman Thatcher Scharpf; German EU spokesperson Julian Fricke; POLITICO's Gabriel Gavin, Jacopo Barigazzi and Camille Gijs.

SPOTTED ... at POLITICO's event "America Votes, Europe Watches: What the U.S. Midterms Mean for Brussels" yesterday, in partnership with Qualcomm: Qualcomm VP for Government Affairs Audrey Scozzaro Ferrazzini; Singapore's Deputy Chief of Mission Yasmin Ali; Burson Brussels CEO Andrew Cecil; European Policy Centre Associate Director Georg Emil Riekeles; IBM Head of Government Affairs EMEA Jean-Marc Leclerc; Fluxys Head of EU Public Affairs Gilles Suply; SAS Chief Privacy Strategist for EMEA and Asia-Pacific Kalliopi Spyridaki; European Banking Federation Director of Legal, International and Social Affairs Blazej Blasikiewicz.

SPOOKY EU LAUGHS: The bubble's favorite comedy, The Schuman Show, is back with a Halloween special on Oct. 21, 22 and 23. Tickets here .

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: While Friedrich Merz gives his big foreign policy speech, Foreign Minister Johann Wadephul is attending the Berlin Process foreign ministers' meeting in Montenegro, where he'll urge the EU to speed up accession for Western Balkan countries.

Paris: The French government will present its draft budget this morning , as some ministers and officials quietly fume that PM Sébastien Lecornu left them out of the process.

London: Nigel Farage will give a speech today in which he's expected to denounce Andy Burnham for opening the door to a return to the EU.

Washington: Republican candidates are increasingly distancing their campaigns from Donald Trump as the party's midterm outlook darkens.

Ottawa: Prime Minister Mark Carney heads to Alberta's oil country to sell his energy reset as the province debates its future in Canada.

Canberra: The Australian government is looking at tearing up its \$2.3 billion contract with the private operator of its onshore immigration detention centers, my colleagues scooped .

AGENDA

— Commission President Ursula von der Leyen is in Kosovo, where she meets President Albulena Haxhiu and Prime Minister Albin Kurti ... and Montenegro, where she meets President Jakov Milatović and Prime Minister Milojk Spajić. Press conference with Spajić at 6:45 p.m. Watch live .

— Informal meeting of health ministers in Dublin. Press conference at 4:30 p.m. Watch live .

— Justice and Home Affairs Council (Home Affairs) in Luxembourg. Press conference with Irish Home Affairs Minister Jim O'Callaghan and EU Migration Commissioner Magnus Brunner at 6 p.m. Watch live .

— Political and Security Committee meets at 10 a.m.

— NATO Secretary-General Mark Rutte meets German Chancellor Friedrich Merz and Dutch Prime Minister Rob Jetten in Münster, Germany. Joint press conference at 1:50 p.m. Rutte will accept the Westphalian Peace Prize 2026 on behalf of NATO and give a speech at the ceremony; Merz will also speak.

— Trade Commissioner Maroš Šefčovič is at the G20 trade ministerial meeting in Milwaukee, Wisconsin.

— Enlargement Commissioner Marta Kos is in Montenegro for the Berlin Process foreign' ministers meeting.

— Defense Commissioner Andrius Kubilius participates in a discussion at the 2026 State of Europe high-level roundtable on "Europe's security moment" at 11:45 a.m. Watch live . He also participates in an extraordinary meeting of the European Parliament's Security and Defense Committee at 10 a.m. Watch live .

— Bellona Climate Action Conference in Brussels, with a keynote by Energy Commissioner Dan Jørgensen. Jørgensen also speaks at the Citizens Energy Forum.

— Commission Executive Vice President Roxana Mînzatu is in Lithuania, where she meets President Gitanas Nausėda, Prime Minister Mindaugas Sinkevičius and Seimas Speaker Juozas Olekas, among others.

— Economy Commissioner Valdis Dombrovskis is in Chişinău, Moldova, where he meets President Maia Sandu, Prime Minister Vasile Tofan, Finance Minister Victoria Belous, Economy Minister Claudiu Năsui and National Bank Governor Anca Dragu. Dombrovskis also gives a keynote at the National Bank of Moldova's annual conference on "Policy Coordination for EU Convergence." Watch live .

— Commission Executive Vice President Henna Virkkunen is in Helsinki, where she meets Finnish Prime Minister Petteri Orpo.

— Commission Executive Vice President Stéphane Séjourné meets Slovenia's Prime Minister Janez Janša in Ljubljana.

BIRTHDAYS

Former European Commissioner and Estonian PM Andrus Ansip; former MEPs Anne Sander, Dominique Martin and Vladimir Urutchev; former Governor of the Central Bank of Luxembourg Yves Mersch; Thyssenkrupp Steel's Julian Schorpp; former British Prime Minister Theresa May; EEAS's Tania Laïci; journalist Teri Schultz.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Grier, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere, Sebastian Starcevic and Gregorio Sorgi. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

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